‘The wind blew hard on that night and the clouds of dust which were flying about made everything darker than usual. When the guns opened fire we saw the ghazis running with torches, which suddenly made the place look like Diwali puja.’[90]

In contrast to the noise of the barrage on the south, the northern side of the fortress was completely silent as Durand and the other engineers began creeping up towards the walls in the darkness. They were anxious as Macnaghten had divulged the whole plan to Shuja’s staff ‘and the scheme of attack, success in which depended on secrecy, had become generally known in the Shah’s camp’. But the plan had not reached the ears of the defenders. In the pre-dawn glimmer, Durand crept up to within 150 yards of the gate before being challenged by a sentry. ‘A shot, and a shout, told that the party had been discovered,’ he wrote later. ‘Instantly the garrison were on alert; their musketry rang free and quick from the ramparts, and blue lights suddenly glared on the top of the battlements, brilliantly illuminating the approach to the gate. A raking fire from the lower outer works, which swept the bridge at half-pistol shot, would have annihilated the engineers and their men, but strange to say, though the ramparts flashed fire from every loophole, the bridge passed without a shot from the lower works.’

The powder bags were deposited and the fuse lit, ‘while the defenders, impatient at the restraint of the loopholes, jumped up onto the tops of their parapets, and poured their fire at the foot of the wall, hurling down stones and bricks’. Running back to cover, the engineers dived into the moat-ditch as a massive explosion rang out, and a bugle sounded the advance.[91] The troops were led into the breach by William Dennie, followed after a pause by a column led by General Robert Sale, known to his men as ‘Fighting Bob’ as he refused to stay at the back and always threw himself into the fiercest hand-to-hand fighting.

Mohammad Husain Herati was watching from the top of the hill near Shah Shuja. ‘The gates of the fortress were blown up,’ he recorded, ‘and the English rushed in fighting hand to hand till the cries of submission rose to the skies “al-Aman! Spare us!” as the Afghan soldiers threw down their arms. Those whose allotted span had reached the limit were killed; others, men and women, were taken off prisoner while all their wealth and possessions and livestock were given over to plunder.’[92] Mirza ‘Ata felt a deep and growing sympathy for the defenders. ‘When they set the fuses alight,’ he wrote,